

Troubleshooting

Something not working? This page covers the most common issues and how to fix them. Each section lists symptoms, likely causes, and step-by-step solutions.

Build errors

Strict mode fails the build

Symptom: `docsforge build` exits with `ERROR: Strict mode is enabled` and points to a file.

Cause: Strict mode treats warnings as errors. Common triggers include missing internal links, invalid Markdown, or files that can't be parsed.

Solution:

1. Check the error message for the exact file and line.
2. Fix the underlying issue, or temporarily disable strict mode to see all warnings:

```
# docsforge.yml
strict: false
```

3. Rebuild, note all warnings, fix them, then re-enable `strict: true`.

Missing files or includes

Symptom: `File not found` or `Include file not found` during build.

Cause: The path in `!include` or `markdown_extensions` references a file that doesn't exist, or the path is relative to the wrong directory.

Solution:

- All paths in `docsforge.yml` are relative to the project root (where `docsforge.yml` lives).
- Check that the file exists at the exact path shown in the error.
- For `extra_css` and `extra_javascript`, paths are relative to the `docs/` directory:

```
# docsforge.yml
extra_css:
  - stylesheets/extra.css  # resolves to docs/stylesheets/extra.css
```

Config validation errors

Symptom: Config value: 'foo'. Expected: str, received: int or similar schema errors.

Cause: A value in `docsforge.yml` has the wrong type.

Solution:

- Check the [Reference](#) for the expected type.
 - Common mistakes:
 - `site_name` must be a string, not a list
 - `nav` items must be strings or nested lists, not integers
 - Plugin options must match their documented schema
-

Search not working

Search index not found

Symptom: Search box shows "No results found" for every query, or the console shows `404` for `search_index.json`.

Cause: The search plugin is disabled, or the index wasn't generated during build.

Solution:

1. Ensure the search plugin is enabled (it is by default):

```
plugins:  
  - search
```

2. Run `docsforge build` — the index is generated at build time, not on the fly.
3. If using a custom `site_url`, verify the base path is correct so the browser can fetch `search_index.json`.

No results for common terms

Symptom: Search box works, but common words return nothing.

Cause: Lunr.js excludes common stop words (`the` , `and` , `is`) and requires exact stem matches.

Solution:

- Use more specific keywords (e.g., search `strict mode` instead of `why is strict mode not working`).
- If you need full-text search with synonyms, consider a third-party search integration.

404 on search page

Symptom: Directly visiting `/search.html` returns 404.

Cause: DocsForge search is a client-side overlay; there is no standalone `/search.html` page.

Solution: Use the search box in the header. It works on every page.

Navigation issues

Sidebar not showing

Symptom: The left sidebar is blank or missing entirely.

Cause: No `nav` section in `docsforge.yml`, or all pages are hidden.

Solution:

1. Explicitly define your navigation:

```
nav:  
  - Home: index.md  
  - Guide: guide.md
```

2. Or rely on automatic discovery by leaving `nav` empty. If the sidebar is still blank, check that your `docs/` directory contains `.md` files.

Sections not expanding

Symptom: Clicking a section header doesn't reveal its children.

Cause: The section page is missing or the section is configured as a link, not a container.

Solution:

- Ensure every section has an `index.md` (or matching file) to act as the parent:

```
nav:  
  - User Guide:  
    - user-guide/index.md
```

- `user-guide/installation.md`
- `user-guide/configuration.md`

- Or use `navigation.expand` to auto-expand all sections:

```
extra:  
  features:  
    - navigation.expand
```

Active state wrong

Symptom: The wrong page is highlighted in the sidebar, or nothing is highlighted.

Cause: The `site_url` or `base_url` is misconfigured, causing path matching to fail.

Solution:

- Set `site_url` to the exact URL where the site is hosted:

```
site_url: https://username.github.io/repository-name/
```

- For local `docsforge serve`, this is handled automatically.
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Asset 404s

CSS or JS not loading

Symptom: Page renders unstyled, or interactive features (tabs, search, dark mode) don't work.

Cause: Browser console shows 404 errors for `.css` or `.js` files.

Solution:

1. Open DevTools → Network tab and check which files are 404.
2. If the paths are wrong, verify `site_url` matches your deployment URL.
3. For GitHub Pages project sites, ensure `site_url` includes the repository path:

```
site_url: https://username.github.io/repository-name/
```

4. If using a CDN or reverse proxy, check that trailing slashes and path rewriting are correct.

Images broken after deployment

Symptom: Images render locally but show as broken links on the deployed site.

Cause: Absolute paths (`/images/foo.png`) or incorrect relative paths.

Solution:

- Use relative paths from the Markdown file location:

```
![Alt text](../images/foo.png)
```

- Or use page-relative syntax with `attr_list`:

```
![Alt text](images/foo.png){ loading=lazy }
```

Math not rendering

KaTeX math blocks not showing

Symptom: `$$...$$` or `\\(...\\)` appears as raw text instead of rendered math.

Cause: The `pymdownx.arithmatex` extension is disabled, or KaTeX assets are blocked.

Solution:

1. Ensure the extension is enabled (default in new projects):

```
markdown_extensions:  
  - pymdownx.arithmatex:  
    generic: true
```

2. Use the correct syntax:

```
$$E = mc^2$$
```

```
Inline: \\(E = mc^2\\)
```

3. If deploying to a CSP-restricted environment, allow `unsafe-inline` for styles or switch to MathJax (configured via custom `extra_javascript`).
-

Code highlighting not working

No syntax colors

Symptom: Code blocks render as plain text without colors.

Cause: `pymdownx.highlight` is disabled, or the language specifier is missing/invalid.

Solution:

1. Ensure the extension is enabled:

```
markdown_extensions:  
  - pymdownx.highlight:  
      anchor_linenums: true
```

2. Specify a valid language after the opening backticks:

```
```python  
def hello():
 print("hello")
```

3. Check the [Pygments lexers list](https://pygments.org/docs/lexers/) for the correct language name.

### Missing language support

**\*\*Symptom:\*\*** A specific language is not highlighted.

**\*\*Cause:\*\*** Pygments doesn't have a lexer for that language, or the language alias is wrong.

**\*\*Solution:\*\***

- Try alternative names (e.g., ``js`` vs ``javascript``, ``bash`` vs ``shell``).
- For custom languages, use ``text`` as a fallback and open an issue to request a lexer.

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## Dark mode not working

### Toggle missing or non-functional

**\*\*Symptom:\*\*** No moon/sun icon in the header, or clicking it does nothing.

**\*\*Cause:\*\*** The palette config is missing, or a custom CSS override is hiding the toggle.

**\*\*Solution:\*\***

1. Ensure the palette is configured in ``docsforge.yml``:

```
```yaml  
extra:  
  palette:  
    - media: "(prefers-color-scheme: light)"  
      scheme: default
```

```
toggle:
  icon: material/weather-night
  name: Switch to dark mode
- media: "(prefers-color-scheme: dark)"
  scheme: slate
  toggle:
    icon: material/weather-sunny
    name: Switch to light mode
```

2. Check `extra_css` for rules that hide `.md-header__button` or override palette colors.

Blog issues

Posts not showing

Symptom: The blog index is empty or 404.

Cause: Blog plugin is disabled, or posts are not in the expected directory.

Solution:

1. Ensure the blog plugin is enabled:

```
plugins:
- blog
```

2. Place posts in `docs/blog/posts/` with a `YYYY-MM-DD-title.md` filename.

3. Include a `date` meta header in each post:

```
---
date: 2024-01-15
---

# My Post Title
```

RSS not generating

Symptom: No `feed_rss_created.xml` in the build output.

Cause: RSS generation is opt-in and requires additional config.

Solution:

```
plugins:
- blog:
  blog_dir: blog
```

```
blog_toc: true
post_date_format: full
archive_date_format: yyyy
archive_url_date_format: yyyy/MM
post_url_date_format: yyyy/MM/dd
post_url_format: "{date}/{slug}"
archive_url_format: "{date}/archive.html"
authors: true
authors_file: "{blog}/.authors.yml"
draft: true
draft_on_serve: true
draft_if_future_date: true
pagination: true
pagination_if_single_page: true
pagination_keep_content: true
categories: true
categories_name: Categories
categories_toc: true
categories_url_format: "category/{slug}.html"
pagination_url_format: "page/{page}.html"
allowed_authors: all
sort_by: date
sort_order: descending
show_total: true
show_category: true
```

For RSS specifically, ensure `blog` plugin is enabled and `post_url_format` is set. RSS feeds are generated automatically in the `blog/` output directory.

Performance issues

Slow builds

Symptom: `docsforge` build takes minutes on a small site.

Cause: Large unoptimized images, many Mermaid/TikZ diagrams, or unnecessary file copying.

Solution:

1. Enable minification:

```
plugins:
  - minify
```

2. Optimize images before adding them to `docs/` (use WebP or compressed PNG).
3. For TikZ diagrams, pre-compile them and commit the SVGs instead of building on every run.

4. Exclude large binary files from `docs/` using `.gitignore` patterns — they are copied to `site/` even if unused.

Large site output

Symptom: `site/` directory is hundreds of megabytes.

Cause: Unoptimized images, video files, or large PDFs in `docs/`.

Solution:

- Use `exclude` in `docsforge.yml` to prevent copying unnecessary files:

```
exclude:  
- "*.mp4"  
- "*.pdf"  
- drafts/
```

- Store large assets elsewhere (CDN, Git LFS) and link to them.
-

Deployment issues

GitHub Pages 404 on every page

Symptom: Only `index.html` works; all other pages return 404.

Cause: GitHub Pages project sites serve from a subdirectory (`/repo-name/`), but `site_url` is missing or incorrect.

Solution:

```
# docsforge.yml  
site_url: https://username.github.io/repository-name/
```

CSS/JS broken on GitHub Pages

Symptom: Site loads but is unstyled.

Cause: Absolute asset paths assume root (`/`), but the site is in a subdirectory.

Solution: Always set `site_url` when deploying to a subdirectory. DocsForge rewrites asset paths based on this value.

CNAME not working

Symptom: Custom domain shows 404 or GitHub Pages default domain.

Cause: `CNAME` file is missing, in the wrong place, or DNS isn't configured.

Solution:

1. Create `docs/CNAME` (no file extension, all caps):

```
docs.example.com
```

2. Configure DNS with a CNAME record pointing to `username.github.io` (for project sites) or `username.github.io` (for user/organization sites).
 3. Wait for DNS propagation (up to 24 hours).
-

Python and environment issues

Version requirements

Symptom: `pip install docsforge` fails with dependency errors.

Cause: Python version is below 3.10, or pip is outdated.

Solution:

```
# Check Python version
python --version # Must be 3.10 or higher

# Upgrade pip
pip install --upgrade pip

# Install in a fresh virtual environment
python -m venv .venv
source .venv/bin/activate # or .venv\Scripts\activate on Windows
pip install docsforge
```

Pip conflicts

Symptom: `docsforge build` fails with `ImportError` or `ModuleNotFoundError`.

Cause: Conflicting versions of `markdown`, `jinja2`, or other dependencies installed globally.

Solution:

1. Always use a virtual environment:

```
python -m venv .venv
source .venv/bin/activate
```

```
pip install --force-reinstall docsforge
```

2. If using Conda, install via pip inside the Conda environment:

```
conda create -n docsforge python=3.11
conda activate docsforge
pip install docsforge
```

FAQ

? Why does `docsforge serve` show old content? >

? Can I use DocsForge with Jupyter notebooks? >

? How do I add a custom 404 page? >

? Why is my `!!! note` admonition not rendering? >

? How do I exclude a page from search? >

? Can I deploy to a subdirectory without `site_url`? >

? Why does the build fail with `jinja2.exceptions.TemplateNotFound`? >

? How do I debug plugin issues? >

? Does DocsForge support multi-language sites? >

? How do I upgrade DocsForge? >

? Where do I report bugs or request features? >

Still stuck?

If none of the above solutions work:

1. Run `docsforge build` and capture the full output.
2. Check your `docsforge.yml` against the [Reference](#).
3. Search existing [GitHub issues](#) for the error message.
4. Open a new issue with:

- `docsforge.yml`
- Python version (`python --version`)
- DocsForge version (`docsforge --version`)
- The exact error message
- Steps to reproduce

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